

GRIN AND BEAR IT: UPA's pride has turned into discomfiture



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regard for Balasaheb." Devisinh's friendship with the head of the RSS in Jalgaon, too, is the talk of the small town. Politics cannot be devoid of friendships, but the high-decibel campaign of the Congress on secularism and probity in public life runs contrary to the litany of charges being aired from within the party and outside. It is also adding to the discomfiture of the UPA allies, especially the Left.

On the face of it, the Congress and the UPA have little to fear. With 5.74 lakh votes in an electoral college of 10.98 lakh, the arithmetic of the politics is in their favour. Add the Shiv Sena's 20,779 votes and the total rises to 5.95 lakh votes, which is 46,000 votes over and above the halfway mark. But it is not the arithmetic that bothers them. It is the algebra of dented perception that is worrying. With

scandal and mud-slinging making the battle ugly, the Congress has put a crack team led by Dasmunshi, along with Prithviraj Chauhan, Suresh Pachouri and Jayanti Natarajan to manage the affairs and the ward. Such is the level of aggression that opposition parties and Third Front members are charging the Congress of using income tax raids on JD(S) sympathisers in Bangalore, CBI cases on Samajwadi Party leader Mulayam Singh, and other methods (the case in the Election Commission against AIADMK leader J. Jayalalithaa) to prevent the challenger, Bhairon Singh Shekhawat, from wooing the fence-sitters. Simultaneously, the Congress has launched a move to get Natwar Singh, who is one of Shekhawat's proposers, disqualified from the Rajya Sabha. It plans to bring up Natwar's involvement in the Volcker scam to offset allegations being thrown at its candidate.

There is good old-fashioned political wooing too. Dasmunshi called up Bhim Singh of the Jammu and Kashmir National Panthers Party as soon as he proposed Shekhawat's name for President, and wooed his votes, saying, "They are saying Shekhawat is the only Lion in the country, what about you?" Bhim Singh's party has a total of four MLAs and no MPs. Total votes: 288, which is just above 0.02 per cent of the electoral college. At another level, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh called Samajwadi Party leader Amar Singh over for tea at his Race Course Road. More action will follow in the days to come, and as Dasmunshi says, will continue till July 19. A week is a long time in politics, and three weeks is way too long. The Congress could win the electoral battle, but political parties survive on public perception. Even Congressmen admit that with their brute majority, they could have done better. The embarrassing choice will not be washed away by a victory and cannot be easily wished away either.

with Satarupa Bhattacharjya

PATIL PHILOSOPHY

A PEEK INTO THE MIND OF THE UPA'S CANDIDATE

"I had a pleasant experience. Dadiji ke shareer mein baba aaye (baba entered the body of Dadiji)."

On her encounter with the late Lekh Raj through Hriday "Dadiji" Mohini, head of the Brahmakumari sect

"The purdah system was introduced to protect women from Muslim invaders. However, times have changed."

On systemic change in Independent India and the purpose of the purdah system

"Whatever religion one practises, he should keep it at home and adopt family planning as the true religion."

On forced sterilisation in the Maharashtra Assembly six months into the Emergency in 1975-76

"Increase in the population should be looked upon as an economic crime on the country."

On population, speaking in the Lok Sabha at an annual debate on the 1993-94 Budget